Rick Clinton

AI Safety Researcher and Program Manager
Chennai, India | clinpeter@gmail.com | github.com/Rick-Clinton-jpg | Research portfolio available on request

PROFILE

Program manager turned independent AI safety researcher. At Walmart I directed an eight-week onboarding program for international sellers across three years, serving 700+ clients with zero client-side escalations. Since July 2026 I have directed an AI-assisted research portfolio on agent containment, authorization, and verification, shipped through public research sprints and hackathons. I set the scope, threat models, acceptance criteria, and evaluation; coding agents assist with implementation, testing, and documentation, and nothing ships on an AI's self-report: every result is checked externally before it is claimed.

CORE STRENGTHS

Program design and end-to-end delivery | Partner and stakeholder management | Onboarding and training programs | Escalation management | Playbooks and process design | AI-native workflows (Claude Code, Codex) with output verification | Evaluation and red-team design | Research writing

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Project Management Specialist — Walmart, Chennai | *August 2022–June 2025*

- Directed an eight-week onboarding program for 15 to 22 international sellers per month across three years, serving 700+ clients with zero client-side escalations; used discovery research to tailor each engagement.
- Served as the primary escalation point and trained the broader business-development team.
- Designed a duplicate-item identification playbook that remains in use; received Stellar Stakeholder Recognition, April 2023.

Catalogue Associate — Amazon Pvt Ltd | *April 2019–May 2021*

- Managed high-volume catalog operations and vendor coordination against defined SLA and quality standards.

RESEARCH SPRINTS AND HACKATHONS

DogWhistle | *AI Collusion Research Sprint, Apart Research* | *October 2026*

- Solo entry, Collusion Carriers and Countermeasures track. Tested whether a schema-valid agent handoff field can carry a hidden codeword that changes a successor agent's actions, and whether an audit can identify the agent acting on it without knowing the code. Repo: github.com/Rick-Clinton-jpg/DogWhistle.
- Directed a label-free audit that compares how much an agent's answers change when a suspect field is swapped against when only the prompt wording changes. It separated the instructed listener from the honest one on 27 of 30 tasks (difference 0.356, 95% CI 0.256 to 0.456, one-sided $p = 2.05 \times 10^{-7}$, 360 of 360 valid calls), and a separate re-analysis reproduced all 30 task values.
- Preregistered six separate studies, committing tasks, prompts, and decision rules before any model call. Reported the two studies that failed their full claims and one retired run alongside the main result, and published the retired run's sealed answers unchanged. Scope stated plainly: one planted code, one synthetic task, one model.

Mirage | *AI Incident Response Sprint, Apart Research × CeSIA* | *September 2026*

- **Result:** Top 25 percent of 222 scored submissions as a solo entry, containment track. Repo: github.com/Rick-Clinton-jpg/Mirage (v0.5.2). After results, addressed reviewer comments on a separate post-sprint branch.
- Directed a three-zone Linux containment experiment treating an AI evaluation sandbox's repository mediator as compromised; 23 of 23 required controls passed and the permitted package path succeeded in 10 of 10 fresh topology trials, while arbitrary destinations, alternate ports, redirect follow-up, and a reverse pivot into management stayed blocked.
- Adversarial review broke the original hash-chain verifier by rewriting and rehashing a failed result into an authenticated pass. Removed it as the default compliance path, required witnessed authentication, and kept the exact forgery as a permanent regression test.
- Exported offline-verifiable evidence (canonical JSONL, witness receipt, signed policy and vulnerability assurance inputs, SHA-256 manifest) so a reviewer can check the result without trusting the originating lab.

Buy or Wait? | *HackerRank Orchestrate* | *September 2026*

- Built a dual-mode financial affordability agent under a 21-hour deadline, with a contradiction check that flagged ambiguous income evidence instead of trusting it. Isolated each safety check's effect on scoring and kept the stricter configuration, accepting 18 of 25 categorical accuracy instead of 20 of 25 to avoid recommending payment plans against unverified income. Ranked 937 of 3,062; certificate verified by HackerRank.

SELECTED RESEARCH AND BUILDS

Mirror World | *v0.8.9.9* | *September 2026*

- Ran adversarial escape campaigns against real free-tier LLMs inside a kernel-hardened sandbox with real seccomp and Linux namespaces; zero real capability grants across every trace event, including against a model that independently discovered a five-step forged-authority escalation chain on its own initiative.
- Found and fixed a timing side-channel that let an attacker tell real operations from deception-layer reflections with 99.2 percent accuracy from response latency alone. After a constant-time fix, a promising 61.3 percent in-sample re-test proved, under held-out cross-validation, to be 52 to 55 percent, consistent with chance.

Armour | *github.com/Rick-Clinton-jpg/Armour* | *August–September 2026*

- Directed a deterministic policy and execution boundary for AI agents: an agent proposes an action; Armour independently authorizes, rejects, or escalates it before a registered handler runs. The project explicitly remains a gate, not a sandbox.
- Hardened production construction to require a trusted isolated Ed25519-or-equivalent approval verifier and a durable, integrity-protected approval ledger; added replay protection, bounded security memory, hash-chained receipts, and optional deletion-detection checkpoints.
- Added single-use filesystem and network capabilities that bind the resource checked to the resource supplied to the handler, reducing destination-substitution races. Public main: 146 passing tests and 20 of 20 modeled mutants killed; no real handler executes during mutation runs.

Chainmail | *github.com/Rick-Clinton-jpg/Chainmail* | *v5.1, September 2026*

- Directed an independently hardened governance layer for long-running multi-agent systems around one invariant: an agent can never delegate more authority than it currently holds. Human-declared authority is the ceiling; contextual signals may only tighten decisions.
- Made replay state, delegated authority, and permission and step budgets durable and atomic in SQLite; production mode fails closed without signatures, durable state, and a non-permissive execution boundary.
- Expanded adversarial evaluation with an authority-laundering family covering over-delegation, stale authority after revocation, forged budget fields, multi-hop laundering, and concurrent double-spend. Fresh local rerun: 203 passed, 8 skipped.

Quorum | *Built for Google's All Things Agentic Hackathon* | *2026*

- Directed a 12-day build and deployment of a gated multi-agent coordinator on Google Cloud Run: a Gemini and Vertex AI worker drafts patches, while three independent deterministic verifiers must agree before a patch can proceed; stages are written to a Firestore audit trail.
- Converted a cross-instance Firestore race, a regex denial-of-service risk, and an unbounded retry loop into reproducing regression tests and fixes; the system opened real, verifiable pull requests only after its checks passed.

Confidence Report and EVAL | *Review tools for my own research* | *2026*

- Designed two review tools so my results are checked against outside standards, not an AI's view of its own work. EVAL picks the statistical checks an experiment needs by fixed rules and computes them with tested code; Confidence Report locks stated beliefs before evidence is gathered, requires evidence for every passed check, and draws on standards such as the NeurIPS checklist, the TRL scale, and CVSS.
- Confidence Report has 42 passing tests; in a blind backtest on Mirage it matched 5 of the 6 findings in a sealed reference analysis. Both tools were used to review DogWhistle.

Moss | *self-healing sandbox containment* | *2026*

- Directed a biologically inspired architecture in which a central supervisor coordinates defensive units that detect and quarantine hostile processes inside a sandbox without acting outside it. Prototype uses HMAC-signed modules and fail-closed capability removal, extended with a Linux enforcement adapter (namespaces, cgroups v2, seccomp) on an isolated VM.

SELECTED WRITING

JUDGE | *position paper, 2026*

A five-layer architecture that turns model behavior into explicit claims checked by deterministic, replayable gates.

Building With a Conditionally Trusted Machine | *working paper, 2026*

Using AI without granting it unearned authority, and the controls built against the knowledge debt it creates.

The Five-Layer Stack | *working paper, August 2026*

A deterministic external-verification stack built from observed failure modes, with invented-entity test cases.

EDUCATION

B.Tech, Mechanical Engineering — SRM University
Diploma, Modern Applied Psychology (DiMAP)